

WE'RE NOT IN THE BUSINESS OF
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Curated by Terry Berlier

1. MFA Thesis Exhibition
2. Stanford University Department
of Art & Art History

FELICITA NORRIS



A *Not White Enough*, 2014. Acrylic and oil on canvas, 96 x 64 in.

THE QUIETUDE OF THE COFFIN

CONOR LAUESEN

Felicita Norris' paintings are voraciously provocative: ruptured balloons rhyme with bodies, and effusive skin is often shown mangled and abused. Her paintings strive to embody experience and emotion. The work accomplishes this not only through content and massive size, but also through an excavation of colors, textures, and space. While the narrative content is imbued with emotive pathos, I am as concerned with the liquid texturing of Norris' work. The painterly thickness of brushwork, her subtle renderings of viscous materiality, and the latent themes of vision and voice engender her work with a set of bodily sensibilities. How does silence look? What are the thresholds of sight? Can painting reappropriate emotional trauma and physical violence? These questions guide her paintings and will help structure this essay. I look first at two paintings: *Thank you for the worthless day*, and *Not White Enough*, each representative of Norris' larger oeuvre. I will then look closely at *Mama's Boy*, suggesting that the stakes of Norris' painting process are most clearly on display in this painting.

It is too simple to say Norris is a representational narrative painter. Sure—the content of her paintings is undeniably tethered to personal histories of violence and trauma, domesticity, and interiority—but this description is lacking something. Let us first consider *Not White Enough*. Similar to most of her work, the large size of the canvas offers us an immediate and tactile immersion into her painterly reality.

A kind of rapacious whiteness dominates the interior scene: pillows, sheets, shoes, and lights are each whiter and more offensively luminous than the next. The viscosity and thickness of materiality are emphasized in meticulously sculpted bed sheets. This interior bombardment of white, however, is more than a trite socio-cultural criticism of race, class, or power. An unidentifiable figure lays curled in the fetal position. Vulnerable and alone, she is veiled by a white sheet: she is faceless and silenced. Here, the body—self, image, and figure—is shown vulnerable to erasure. Any recognizable identity is suffocated in the fleshy rippled layers of whiteness: white shoes are the only remaining marks of any individuality. It is as if the white halo of the light bulb has replaced her head. The covered body has been drained from head to toe.

Similar themes are present in *Thank you for the worthless day*. Two partially nude figures stand side by side in a shower. Heads wrapped in plastic, they are both silenced and blinded. The violent elasticity of materials—plastic webs, fleshy bodies, and a kind of surgical tape—is rendered palpable. Hyperbolically luminous colors delineate forms and texture; specifically, red tape strangles, purple glass shimmers, and white plastic grips abdomens and heads. The uncanny disquietude in the two figures feels strangely analogous to the now infamous torture photographs from Abu Ghraib. Blurred thresholds of violence and the stakes of silence are confronted as one is beheld by the work. There is a glowing magnetism, unsettling and vociferous, that reminds me of Gregory Crewdson's photographs: both artists illuminate the architecture of space through subtle manipulations of color and shadow. Tragedy is not over-sentimentalized; rather, the potency of trauma is articulated through the inchoate.

With delicate brushwork, *Mama's Boy*, Norris' most recent painting, poetically condenses myriad themes of her work. How does *Mama's Boy* accomplish this refined articulation in paint? First, let us note the unique horizontal composition of the painting. *Mama's Boy* implores the visual language of Hans Holbein's master painting, *The Body of the Dead Christ in the Tomb* (1520-22): extreme horizontality, coffins and caskets, death, and stillness proliferate. Bandaged in black we see a mummy-like body; the deafening quietude of this cloaked and elongated figure fills nearly the entire canvas. A melancholic stillness permeates. While we recognize the contours of a horizontally-stretched body, human flesh and meticulous verisimilitude of narrative representation are here evacuated. The embodiment of sculpted plastic edges, the tactility

of translucent fabrics, and the brazen display of bulbous bodies are refined to a hooded and solitary horizontal figure. Voice and sight are fully effaced. The only visible skin of the faceless corpse is the foot: the big toe seems to protrude outward, activating our space. Holbein's depiction of Christ's hand—dead, yet still palpable, with spider-like frozen fingers—feels strangely present in the fleshy toes of *Mama's Boy*. While Norris' most recent painting is still committed to figuration, there is simultaneously an approximation towards abstraction. If the cacophony of her previous paintings—narrative representations of trauma, viscous colors illuminating space, and motifs of translucent balloons and bags—is a declarative proclamation, then *Mama's Boy* is a grief-laden silent hush.

B *Mama's Boy*, 2015. Oil on linen, 82 x 27 in.

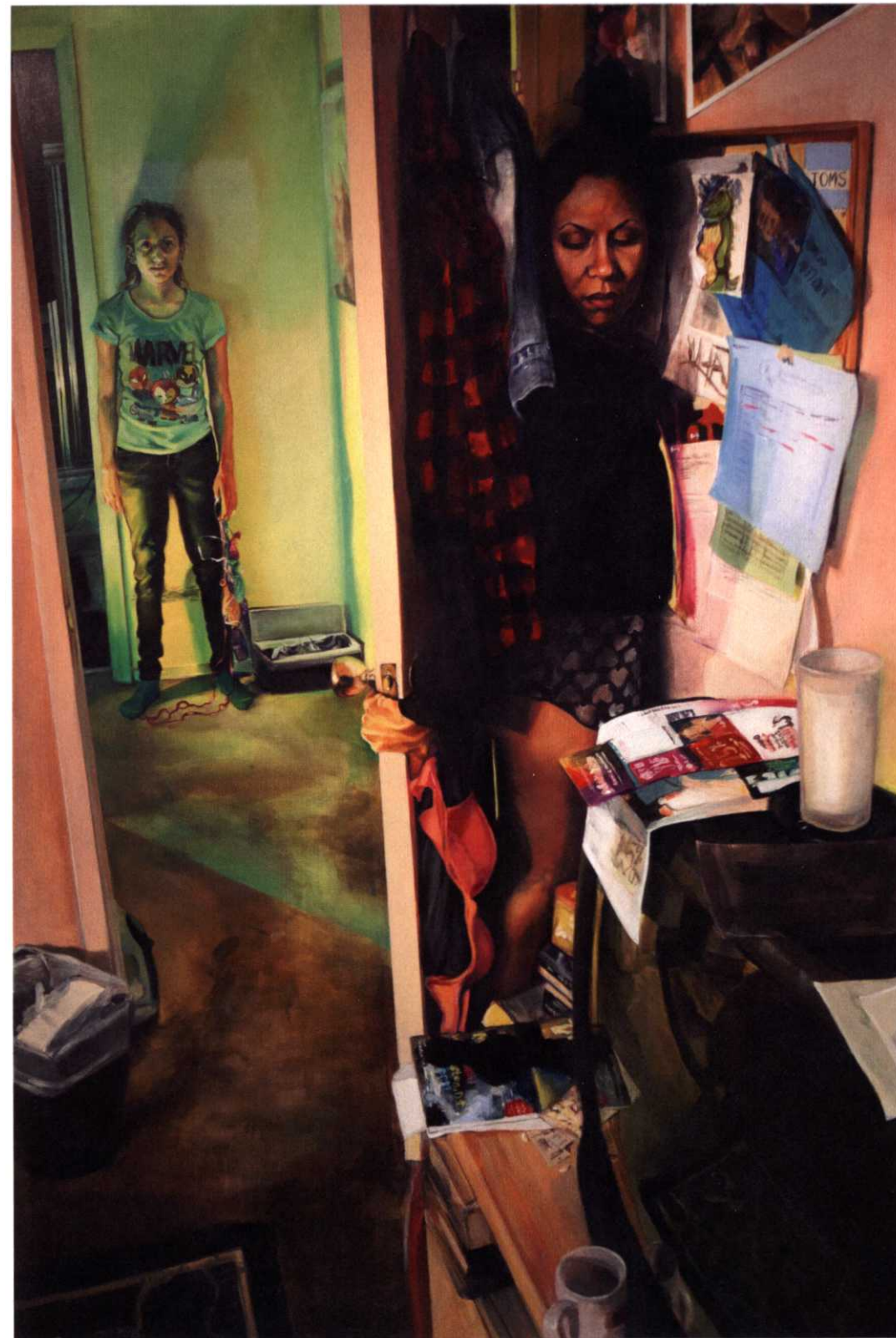
C *Thank you for the worthless day*, 2015. Acrylic and oil on canvas, 48 x 96 in.



B



C



A SERIES OF TRANSFORMATIONS

MARIA CICHOSZ

Felicita Norris' work breathes the magic of the figurative. Significations slide, and objects, though concrete, are not necessarily what they appear. A series of transformations burst upon us—a shift in angle, a flood of color just a shade too sickly to be of this world, a figure we think we recognize only to realize we don't. Reeling with vertigo that stems from the artist but becomes our own, we fall into a gap in which we are invited to witness nothing less than the birth of meaning, its stubborn repetitive pull, and the mysterious alchemy of all that befalls it between points of repetition.

The artist has vivid, intense dreams haunted by the violent and the strange. Dreams are the catalyst for her process, in which the intensity of a feeling is preserved in an image. Talking about *Mama's Boy*, Norris explains: "It is about a feeling. I just needed to have that white man under that black bag." How does something amorphous, a *felt realization*, become a powerful visual representation? To take a dream seriously is a radical act. In the contemporary art context, where conceptual and non-representational art is dominant, privileging the realms of dream, emotion, spirituality, and symbology requires a commitment to the subconscious, to instinct, and to the lived truth of the human body, inseparable from the visual strangeness of psychic life. The non-linguistic realm of dreams holds its own logic, available only to those who pay attention to its contours and recurrences.

Norris' paintings resonate with a powerful affective force of fear—the fear of death, bondage, and entrapment. Such forces impose severe limits on human potential for action. The frustrated desire for whiteness and its trappings results in reversals of visual intensity: there are the muted, soft colors of *Not White Enough* clashing directly with the violent red floodlight and extreme contrasts of *Mama's Boy*. Both paintings contain a plasticity—literally, in *Mama's Boy*, a plastic garbage bag—that immerses and covers the human figure depicted therein. Plasticity refers as much to surface, falseness, and appearance as to mutability and the potential for change, or the *desire* to change. Both paintings are emotional responses to something the artist can't have, yet desires.

In desire we see emotion, thought, experience, and history merge into symbols that cannot be disentangled in any definitive way. Such ambiguity implicates the viewer, who is pulled into limerence and asked compulsively to fill in the gaps. In Norris' transformations, ordinary domestic objects become staged props, pieces of a mystery, or fragments of a narrative that may be reconfigured into any number of constellations. Cheap plastic hangers, red tape, McDonald's cups, and disposable water bottles blur lines between real and psychic clutter—the objects are really *there*, yet they also point elsewhere, constituting a scene layered with meaning. To be drawn in close to the painting is to see these familiar and layered objects dissolve before our eyes into textures of oil paint, decontextualized and disorienting, another vertiginous turn defying our desire for coherence.

Limerence is a compulsion to repeat, and transformation is ultimately a repetition with difference. Limerence, then, though

D *Bitch in Sheep's Clothing*, 2014. Acrylic and oil on canvas, 56 x 84 in.